

# Elon Musk

## A Comprehensive Research Biography

14 July 2026

# Contents

---

1. Introduction
2. Image Gallery
3. Career and Contributions
4. Recent Developments
5. References

# Chapter 1

## Introduction

---

Elon Reeve Musk ( EE-lon; born June 28, 1971) is a businessman and former public official who is the CEO and largest shareholder of Tesla and SpaceX. Musk has been the wealthiest person in the world since 2025, and became the only trillionaire in terms of US dollars in June 2026; as of July 10, 2026, Forbes estimates his net worth to be US\$917 billion. Born into the wealthy Musk family in Pretoria, South Africa, Musk emigrated in 1989 to Canada; he has Canadian citizenship since his mother was born there. He received bachelor's degrees in 1997 from the University of Pennsylvania before moving to California to pursue business ventures. In 1995, Musk co-founded Zip2, a web software company. Following its sale in 1999, he co-founded X.com, an e-commerce payment system that merged with Confinity in March 2000 to form PayPal, which was acquired by eBay in 2002. Musk also became an American citizen in 2002. In 2002, Musk founded and became CEO and chief engineer of SpaceX, a space technology company; the company has since led innovations in reusable rockets and commercial spaceflight. Musk joined Tesla as an early investor in 2004 and became its CEO and product architect in 2008; it has since become a leader in electric vehicles. In 2015, Musk co-founded OpenAI to advance artificial intelligence (AI) research, but later left; his growing discontent with the organization's direction and leadership in the AI boom in the 2020s led him to establish xAI, which became a subsidiary of SpaceX in 2026. In 2022, he acquired Twitter, a social networking service; he implemented significant changes and rebranded it as X in 2023. His other businesses include Neuralink, a neurotechnology company that he co-founded in 2016, and the Boring Company, a tunneling company that he founded in 2017. In November 2025, Tesla approved a pay package worth \$1 trillion for Musk, which he is to receive over 10 years if certain milestones are met, such as achieving a market capitalization of \$8.5 trillion. Musk is a supporter of global far-right politics, figures, and political parties. He was the largest donor in the 2024 U.S. presidential election, where he supported Donald Trump. After Trump was inaugurated in January 2025, Musk served as Senior Advisor to the President and as the de facto head of the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE). Musk left the Trump administration in May 2025 and returned to managing his companies; shortly thereafter he had a public feud with Trump. Musk's political activities, statements and views have made him a polarizing figure. He has been criticized for making unscientific and misleading statements, including spreading COVID-19 misinformation, promoting conspiracy theories, and affirming antisemitic, white nationalist, racist, and transphobic comments. His acquisition of Twitter was controversial because, following his pledge to decrease censorship, there was an increase in hate speech and misinformation on the service. His role in the second Trump administration attracted public backlash, particularly in response to DOGE and its cuts to the US Agency for International Development (USAID).

# Chapter 2

## Image Gallery

---





# Chapter 3

## Career and Contributions

---

### Early life and education

Elon Reeve Musk was born on June 28, 1971, in Pretoria, South Africa's administrative capital. He is of British and Pennsylvania Dutch ancestry. His mother, Maye (née Haldeman), is a model and dietitian born in Saskatchewan, Canada, and raised in South Africa. Musk therefore holds both South African and Canadian citizenship from birth. His father, Errol Musk, is a South African electromechanical engineer, pilot, sailor, consultant, emerald dealer, and property developer, who partly owned a rental lodge at Timbavati Private Nature Reserve. His maternal grandfather, Joshua N. Haldeman, who died in a plane crash when Musk was a toddler, was an American-born Canadian chiropractor, aviator and political activist in the Technocracy movement who moved to South Africa in 1950. Haldeman's anti-government, anti-democratic and conspiracist views, which included the promotion of far-right antisemitic conspiracy theories, "fanatical" support of apartheid, and according to Errol, support of Nazism, have been suggested as an influence on Musk. During his childhood, Musk was told stories by his grandmother of Haldeman's travels and exploits, and he has suggested that all of Haldeman's descendants have his "desire for adventure, exploration – doing crazy things". Musk has a younger brother, Kimbal, a younger sister, Tosca, and four paternal half-siblings. He was baptized as a child in the Anglican Church of Southern Africa. The Musk family was wealthy during his youth. Despite both Musk and Errol previously stating that Errol was a part owner of a Zambian emerald mine, in 2023, Errol recounted that the deal he made was to receive "a portion of the emeralds produced at three small mines". Errol was elected to the Pretoria City Council as a representative of the anti-apartheid Progressive Party and has said that his children shared their father's dislike of apartheid. After his parents divorced in 1979, Musk, aged around 9, chose to live with his father because he had an Encyclopædia Britannica set and a computer. He later regretted his decision and became estranged from his father. Musk has recounted trips to a wilderness school that he described as a "paramilitary Lord of the Flies" where "bullying was a virtue" and children were encouraged to fight over rations. In one incident, after an altercation with a fellow pupil, Musk was thrown down concrete steps and beaten severely, leading to him being hospitalized for his injuries. He described his father berating him after he was discharged from the hospital. Errol denied berating Musk and claimed, "The [other] boy had just lost his father to suicide, and Musk had called him stupid. He had a tendency to call people stupid. How could I possibly blame that child?" Musk was an enthusiastic reader of books, and had attributed his success in part to having read *The Lord of the Rings*, the *Foundation* series, and *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*. At age ten, he developed an interest in computing and video games, teaching himself how to program from the VIC-20 user manual. At age twelve, in 1983, Musk sold his BASIC-based game *Blastar* to PC and Office Technology

magazine for approximately \$500 (equivalent to \$1,600 in 2025).

## Education

Musk attended Waterkloof House Preparatory School, Bryanston High School, and then Pretoria Boys High School, where he graduated. Musk was a decent but unexceptional student, earning a 61/100 in Afrikaans and a B on his senior math certification. Musk applied for a Canadian passport through his Canadian-born mother to avoid South Africa's mandatory military service, which would have forced him to participate in the apartheid regime's mandatory military service for young white South African men, as well as to ease his path to immigration to the United States. While waiting for his application to be processed, he attended the University of Pretoria for five months. Musk arrived in Canada in June 1989, connected with a second cousin in Saskatchewan, and worked odd jobs, including at a farm and a lumber mill. In 1990, he entered Queen's University in Kingston, Ontario. Two years later, he transferred to the University of Pennsylvania, where he studied until 1995. Although Musk has said that he earned his degrees in 1995, the University of Pennsylvania did not award them until 1997 – a Bachelor of Arts in physics and a Bachelor of Science in economics from the university's Wharton School. He reportedly hosted large, ticketed house parties to help pay for tuition, and wrote a business plan for an electronic book-scanning service similar to Google Books. In 1994, Musk held two internships in Silicon Valley: one at energy storage startup Pinnacle Research Institute, which investigated electrolytic supercapacitors for energy storage, and another at Palo Alto-based startup Rocket Science Games. In 1995, he was accepted to a graduate program in materials science at Stanford University, but did not enroll. Musk decided to join the Internet boom of the 1990s, applying for a job at Netscape, to which he reportedly never received a response. The Washington Post reported that Musk lacked legal authorization to remain and work in the United States after failing to enroll at Stanford. In response, Musk said he was allowed to work at that time and that his student visa transitioned to an H1-B. According to numerous former business associates and shareholders, Musk said he was on a student visa at the time.

## Business career

### Zip2

In 1995, Musk, his brother Kimbal, and Greg Kouri founded Zip2, a web software company, with funding from a group of angel investors. They housed the venture at a small rented office in Palo Alto. Replying to Rolling Stone, Musk denounced the notion that they started their company with funds borrowed from Musk's father Errol Musk, but in a tweet, he recognized that his father contributed 10% of a later funding round. The company developed and marketed an Internet city guide for the newspaper publishing industry, with maps, directions, and yellow pages. According to Musk, "The website was up during the day and I was coding it at night, seven days a week, all the time." To impress investors, Musk built a large plastic structure around a standard computer to

create the impression that Zip2 was powered by a small supercomputer. The Musk brothers obtained contracts with The New York Times and the Chicago Tribune, and persuaded the board of directors to abandon plans for a merger with CitySearch. Musk's attempts to become CEO were thwarted by the board. Compaq acquired Zip2 for \$307 million in cash in February 1999 (equivalent to \$590,000,000 in 2025), and Musk received \$22 million (equivalent to \$43,000,000 in 2025) for his 7-percent share.

## **X.com and PayPal**

In 1999, Musk co-founded X.com, an online financial services and e-mail payment company. The startup was one of the first federally insured online banks, and, in its initial months of operation, over 200,000 customers joined the service. The company's investors regarded Musk as inexperienced and replaced him with Intuit CEO Bill Harris by the end of the year. The following year, X.com merged with online bank Confinity to avoid competition. Founded by Max Levchin and Peter Thiel, Confinity had its own money-transfer service, PayPal, which was more popular than X.com's service. Within the merged company, Musk returned as CEO. Musk's preference for Microsoft software over Unix created a rift in the company and caused Thiel to resign. Due to resulting technological issues and lack of a cohesive business model, the board ousted Musk and replaced him with Thiel in 2000. Under Thiel, the company focused on the PayPal service and was renamed PayPal in 2001. In 2002, PayPal was acquired by eBay for \$1.5 billion (equivalent to \$2,700,000,000 in 2025) in stock, of which Musk—the largest shareholder with 11.72% of shares—received \$175.8 million (equivalent to \$320,000,000 in 2025). In 2017, Musk purchased the domain X.com from PayPal for an undisclosed amount, stating that it had sentimental value.

## **SpaceX**

In 2001, Musk became involved with the nonprofit Mars Society and discussed funding plans to place a growth-chamber for plants on Mars. Seeking a way to launch the greenhouse payloads into space, Musk made two unsuccessful trips to Moscow to purchase intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs) from Russian companies NPO Lavochkin and Kosmotras. Musk instead decided to start a company to build affordable rockets. With \$100 million of his early fortune, (equivalent to \$180,000,000 in 2025) Musk founded SpaceX in May 2002 and became the company's CEO and Chief Engineer. SpaceX attempted its first launch of the Falcon 1 rocket in 2006. Although the rocket failed to reach Earth orbit, it was awarded a Commercial Orbital Transportation Services program contract from NASA, then led by Mike Griffin. After two more failed attempts that nearly caused Musk to go bankrupt, SpaceX succeeded in launching the Falcon 1 into orbit in 2008. Later that year, SpaceX received a \$1.6 billion NASA contract (equivalent to \$2,400,000,000 in 2025) for Falcon 9-launched Dragon spacecraft flights to the International Space Station (ISS), replacing the Space Shuttle after its 2011 retirement. In 2012, the Dragon vehicle docked with the ISS, a first for a commercial spacecraft. Working towards its goal of reusable rockets, in 2015



SpaceX successfully landed the first stage of a Falcon 9 on a land platform. Later landings were achieved on autonomous spaceport drone ships, an ocean-based recovery platform. In 2018, SpaceX launched the Falcon Heavy; the inaugural mission carried Musk's personal Tesla Roadster as a dummy payload. Since 2019, SpaceX has been developing Starship, a reusable, super heavy-lift launch vehicle intended to replace the Falcon 9 and Falcon Heavy. In 2020, SpaceX launched its first crewed flight, the Demo-2, becoming the first private company to place astronauts into orbit and dock a crewed spacecraft with the ISS. In 2024, NASA awarded SpaceX an \$843 million (equivalent to \$865,000,000 in 2025) contract to build a spacecraft that NASA will use to deorbit the ISS at the end of its lifespan.

## **Tesla**

Tesla, Inc., originally Tesla Motors, was incorporated in July 2003 by Martin Eberhard and Marc Tarpenning. Both men played active roles in the company's early development prior to Musk's involvement. Musk led the Series A round of investment in February 2004; he invested \$6.35 million (equivalent to \$11,000,000 in 2025), became the majority shareholder, and joined Tesla's board of directors as chairman. Musk took an active role within the company and oversaw Roadster product design, but was not deeply involved in day-to-day business operations. Following a series of escalating conflicts in 2007 and the 2008 financial crisis, Eberhard was ousted from the firm. Musk assumed leadership of the company as CEO and product architect in 2008. A 2009 lawsuit settlement with Eberhard designated Musk as a Tesla co-founder, along with Tarpenning and two others. Tesla began delivery of the Roadster, an electric sports car, in 2008. With sales of about 2,500 vehicles, it was the first mass production all-electric car to use lithium-ion battery cells. Under Musk, Tesla has since launched several well-selling electric vehicles, including the four-door sedan Model S (2012), the crossover Model X (2015), the mass-market sedan Model 3 (2017), the crossover Model Y (2020), and the pickup truck Cybertruck (2023). The company has also constructed multiple lithium-ion battery and electric vehicle factories, called Gigafactories. In 2026, Jon McNeill, who served as president of Tesla from 2015 to 2018 and oversaw a period of revenue growth from \$2 billion to \$20 billion, published *The Algorithm*, a book detailing the five-step operational framework used at Tesla and SpaceX. In May 2020, Musk resigned as chairman of the board as part of the settlement of a lawsuit from the SEC over him tweeting that funding had been "secured" for potentially taking Tesla private. Since its initial public offering in 2010, Tesla stock has risen significantly; it became the most valuable carmaker in summer 2020, and it entered the S&P 500 later that year. In October 2021, it reached a market capitalization of \$1 trillion (equivalent to \$1,200,000,000,000 in 2025), the sixth company in U.S. history to do so.

## **Neuralink**

In 2016, Musk co-founded Neuralink, a neurotechnology startup, with an investment of \$100 million. Neuralink aims to integrate the human brain with artificial intelligence (AI) by creating devices that are embedded in the brain. Such technology could enhance memory or allow the devices to communicate with software. The company also hopes to develop devices to treat neurological conditions like spinal cord injuries. In 2022, Neuralink announced that clinical trials would begin by the end of the year. In September 2023, the Food and Drug Administration approved Neuralink to initiate six-year human trials. Neuralink has conducted animal testing on macaques at the University of California, Davis. In 2021, the company released a video in which a macaque played the video game Pong via a Neuralink implant. The company's animal trials—which have caused the deaths of some monkeys—have led to claims of animal cruelty. The Physicians Committee for Responsible Medicine has alleged that Neuralink violated the Animal Welfare Act. Employees have complained that pressure from Musk to accelerate development has led to botched experiments and unnecessary animal deaths. In 2022, a federal probe was launched into possible animal welfare violations by Neuralink.

## **The Boring Company**

In 2017, Musk founded the Boring Company to construct tunnels; he also revealed plans for specialized, underground, high-occupancy vehicles that could travel up to 150 miles per hour (240 km/h) and thus circumvent above-ground traffic in major cities. Early in 2017, the company began discussions with regulatory bodies and initiated construction of a 30-foot (9.1 m) wide, 50-foot (15 m) long, and 15-foot (4.6 m) deep "test trench" on the premises of SpaceX's offices, as that required no permits. The Los Angeles tunnel, less than two miles (3.2 km) in length, debuted to journalists in 2018. It used Tesla Model Xs and was reported to be a rough ride while traveling at suboptimal speeds. Two tunnel projects announced in 2018, in Chicago and West Los Angeles, have been canceled. A tunnel beneath the Las Vegas Convention Center was completed in early 2021. Local officials have approved further expansions of the tunnel system.

## **X Corp.**

In early 2017, Musk expressed interest in buying Twitter and had questioned the platform's commitment to freedom of speech. By 2022, Musk had reached 9.2% stake in the company, making him the largest shareholder. Musk later agreed to a deal that would appoint him to Twitter's board of directors and prohibit him from acquiring more than 14.9% of the company. Days later, Musk made a \$43 billion offer to buy Twitter. By the end of April Musk had successfully concluded his bid for approximately \$44 billion. This included approximately \$12.5 billion in loans and \$21 billion in equity financing. Having backtracked on his initial decision, Musk bought the company on October 27, 2022. Immediately after the acquisition, Musk fired several top Twitter executives including CEO Parag Agrawal; Musk became the CEO instead. Under Musk, Twitter instituted monthly subscriptions for a "blue check", and laid off a significant portion of the

company's staff. Musk lessened content moderation and hate speech also increased on the platform after his takeover. In late 2022, Musk released internal documents relating to Twitter's moderation of Hunter Biden's laptop controversy in the lead-up to the 2020 presidential election. Musk also promised to step down as CEO after a Twitter poll, and five months later, Musk stepped down as CEO and transitioned his role to executive chairman and chief technology officer (CTO). Despite Musk stepping down as CEO, X continues to struggle with challenges such as viral misinformation, hate speech, and antisemitism controversies. Musk has been accused of trying to silence some of his critics such as Twitch streamer Asmongold, who criticized him during one of his streams. Musk has been accused of removing their accounts' blue checkmarks, which hinders visibility and is considered a form of shadow banning, or suspending their accounts without justification.

## **Other activities**

### **Hyperloop**

In August 2013, Musk announced plans for a version of a vactrain, and assigned engineers from SpaceX and Tesla to design a transport system between Greater Los Angeles and the San Francisco Bay Area, at an estimated cost of \$6 billion. Later that year, Musk unveiled the concept, dubbed the Hyperloop, intended to make travel cheaper than any other mode of transport for such long distances.

### **OpenAI and xAI**

In December 2015, Musk co-founded OpenAI, a not-for-profit artificial intelligence (AI) research company aiming to develop artificial general intelligence, intended to be safe and beneficial to humanity. Musk pledged \$1 billion of funding to the company, but only donated \$50 million. In 2018, Musk left the OpenAI board. Since 2018, OpenAI has made significant advances in machine learning. In July 2023, Musk launched the artificial intelligence company xAI, which aims to develop a generative AI program that competes with existing offerings like OpenAI's ChatGPT. Musk obtained funding from investors in SpaceX and Tesla, and xAI hired engineers from Google and OpenAI.

### **Private jet**

Musk uses a private jet owned by Falcon Landing LLC, a SpaceX-linked company, and acquired a second jet in August 2020. His heavy use of the jets and the consequent fossil fuel usage have received criticism. Musk's flight usage is tracked on social media through ElonJet. In December 2022, Musk banned the ElonJet account on Twitter, and made temporary bans on the accounts of journalists that posted stories regarding the incident, including Donie O'Sullivan, Keith Olbermann, and journalists from The New York Times, The Washington Post, CNN, and The Intercept.

## Politics

Musk is an outlier among business leaders who typically avoid partisan political advocacy. Musk was a registered independent voter when he lived in California. Historically, he has donated to both Democrats and Republicans, many of whom serve in states in which he has a vested interest. Musk supported Democrat Barack Obama in 2008 and 2012, Democrat Hillary Clinton in 2016, and Democrat Joe Biden in 2020. In the 2020 Democratic Party presidential primaries, Musk endorsed candidate Andrew Yang and expressed support for Yang's proposed universal basic income, and endorsed Kanye West's 2020 presidential campaign. On August 5, 2021, Biden signed an Executive Order targeting that half of cars sold in 2030 should be electric. General Motors CEO Mary Barra was in attendance. Musk commented, "seems odd that Tesla wasn't invited." Barra said in 2024 Musk never forgave not being invited. In 2025, former vice president Kamala Harris said that she believed that not inviting Musk was a "big mistake." In September 2021, Musk criticized Biden as "not the friendliest administration." In December 2021, Musk publicly expressed opposition to the Build Back Better Act. Since 2022, his political contributions have mostly supported Republicans, with his first vote for a Republican going to Mayra Flores in the 2022 Texas's 34th congressional district special election. In 2022, Musk gave over \$50 million to Citizens for Sanity, a conservative political action committee. In 2023, he supported Republican Ron DeSantis for the 2024 U.S. presidential election, giving \$10 million to his campaign, and hosted DeSantis's campaign announcement on a Twitter Spaces event. From June 2023 to January 2024, Musk hosted a bipartisan set of X Spaces with Republican and Democratic candidates, including Robert F. Kennedy Jr., Vivek Ramaswamy, and Dean Phillips. In 2024, he started supporting international far-right political parties, activists, and causes, and has shared far-right misinformation and numerous conspiracy theories. Since 2024, his views have been generally described as right-wing. By the middle of 2024, Musk had become a vocal and financial supporter of Donald Trump. In July 2024, minutes after Trump survived an assassination attempt while speaking in Butler, Pennsylvania, Musk endorsed him for president saying; "I fully endorse President Trump and hope for his rapid recovery." During the presidential campaign, Musk joined Trump on stage at a campaign rally, and during the campaign promoted conspiracy theories and falsehoods about Democrats, election fraud and immigration, in support of Trump. Musk was the largest individual donor of the 2024 election. One PAC funded by Musk created and aired deceptive "false-flag" advertisements appearing to come from progressive organizations in order to misrepresent Kamala Harris's positions. Jacob Silverman, author of the 2025 book *Gilded Rage: Elon Musk and the Radicalization of Silicon Valley*, said that the tech industry represented by Musk, Thiel, Andreessen and other capitalists, actually flourished under Biden, but the tech leaders chose Trump for their common ground on cultural issues. In 2023, Musk said he shunned the World Economic Forum (WEF) because it was boring. The organization commented that they had not invited him since 2015. Musk made a last-minute WEF debut in an interview with the organization's interim co-chair Larry Fink during the 2026 WEF. He also participated in Dialog, dubbed "Tech Bilderberg" and organized by Peter Thiel and Auren Hoffman. Starting in January

2025, Musk's international political actions and comments came under increasing scrutiny and criticism, especially from the governments and leaders of France, Germany, Norway, Spain and the United Kingdom, particularly due to his position in the U.S. government from January to May 2025, as well as ownership of X. A February 2025 NBC News analysis found he had boosted far-right political movements to cut immigration and curtail regulation of business in at least 18 countries on six continents since 2023. In 2025, Musk contributed \$19 million to the Wisconsin Supreme Court race, hoping to influence the state's future redistricting efforts and its regulations governing car manufacturers and dealers.

## **Salute at Trump's second inauguration**

During his speech after the second inauguration of Donald Trump, Musk twice made a gesture interpreted by many as a Nazi or a fascist Roman salute. He thumped his right hand over his heart, fingers spread wide, and then extended his right arm out, emphatically, at an upward angle, palm down and fingers together. He then repeated the gesture to the crowd behind him. As he finished the gestures, he said to the crowd, "My heart goes out to you. It is thanks to you that the future of civilization is assured." It was widely condemned as an intentional Nazi salute in Germany, where making such gestures is illegal. The Anti-Defamation League said it was not a Nazi salute, but other Jewish organizations disagreed and condemned the salute. American public opinion was divided on partisan lines as to whether it was a fascist salute. Musk dismissed the accusations of Nazi sympathies, deriding them as "dirty tricks" and a "tired" attack. Neo-Nazi and white supremacist groups celebrated it as a Nazi salute. Multiple European political parties demanded that Musk be banned from entering their countries.

## **Department of Government Efficiency**

The concept of DOGE emerged in a discussion between Musk and Donald Trump, and in August 2024, Trump committed to giving Musk an advisory role, with Musk accepting the offer. In November and December 2024, Musk suggested that the organization could help to cut the U.S. federal budget, consolidate the number of federal agencies, and eliminate the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, and that its final stage would be "deleting itself". In January 2025, the organization was created by executive order, and Musk was designated a "special government employee". Musk led the organization and was a senior advisor to the president, although his official role is not clear. In sworn statement during a lawsuit, the director of the White House Office of Administration stated that Musk "is not an employee of the U.S. DOGE Service or U.S. DOGE Service Temporary Organization", "is not the U.S. DOGE Service administrator", and has "no actual or formal authority to make government decisions himself". Trump said two days later that he had put Musk in charge of DOGE. A federal judge has ruled that Musk acted as the de facto leader of DOGE. Musk's role in the second Trump administration, particularly in response to DOGE, has attracted public backlash. He was criticized for his treatment of federal government employees, including his influence over the mass layoffs of the federal workforce. He has

prioritized secrecy within the organization and has accused others of violating privacy laws. A Senate report alleged that Musk could avoid up to \$2 billion in legal liability as a result of DOGE's actions. In May 2025, Bill Gates accused Musk of "killing the world's poorest children" through his cuts to USAID. Modeling by Boston University estimated the cuts resulted in 400,000 children and 200,000 adults deaths by November. Musk departed on May 28, 2025, when the special government employee's 130 day deadline expired.

## **Feud with Donald Trump**

After leaving office, Musk criticized the Trump administration's Big Beautiful Bill, calling it a "disgusting abomination" due to its provisions increasing the deficit. A feud began between Musk and Trump, with its most notable event being Musk alleging Trump had ties to sex offender Jeffrey Epstein on X (formerly Twitter) on June 5, 2025. Trump responded on Truth Social stating that Musk went "CRAZY" after the "EV Mandate" was purportedly taken away and threatened to cut Musk's government contracts. Musk then called for a third Trump impeachment. The next day, Trump stated that he did not wish to reconcile with Musk, and added that Musk would face "very serious consequences" if he funds Democratic candidates. On June 11, Musk publicly apologized for the tweets against Trump before deleting them, saying they "went too far".

## **Views**

Rejecting the conservative label, Musk has described himself as a political moderate, even as his views have become more right-wing over time. His views have been characterized as libertarian and far-right, and after his involvement in European politics, they have received criticism from world leaders such as Emmanuel Macron and Olaf Scholz. Within the context of American politics, Musk supported Democratic candidates up until 2022, at which point he voted for a Republican for the first time. He has stated support for universal basic income, gun rights, freedom of speech, a tax on carbon emissions, and H-1B visas. Musk has expressed concern about issues such as artificial intelligence (AI) and climate change, and has been a critic of wealth tax, short-selling, and government subsidies. An immigrant himself, Musk has been accused of being anti-immigration, and regularly blames immigration policies for illegal immigration. He is also a pronatalist who believes population decline is the biggest threat to civilization, and identifies as a cultural Christian. Musk has long been an advocate for space colonization, especially the colonization of Mars. He has repeatedly pushed for humanity colonizing Mars, in order to become an interplanetary species and lower the risks of human extinction. Musk has promoted conspiracy theories and made controversial statements that have led to accusations of racism, sexism, antisemitism, transphobia, disseminating disinformation, and support of white pride. While describing himself as a "pro-Semite", his comments regarding George Soros and Jewish communities have been condemned by the Anti-Defamation League and the Biden White House. Musk was criticized during the COVID-19 pandemic for making unfounded epidemiological claims,

defying COVID-19 lockdowns restrictions, and supporting the Canada convoy protest against vaccine mandates. He has amplified false claims of white genocide in South Africa.

## **International relations**

Musk has been critical of Israel's actions in the Gaza Strip during the Gaza war, praised China's economic and climate goals, suggested that Taiwan and China should resolve cross-strait relations, and was described as having a close relationship with the Chinese government. In Europe, Musk expressed support for Ukraine in 2022 during the Russian invasion, recommended referendums and peace deals on the annexed Russia-occupied territories, and supported the far-right Alternative for Germany political party in 2024. Regarding British politics, Musk blamed the 2024 UK riots on mass migration and open borders, criticized Prime Minister Keir Starmer for what he described as a "two-tier" policing system, and was subsequently attacked as being responsible for spreading misinformation and amplifying the far-right. Musk has publicly supported far-right activist Tommy Robinson, and initially pledged financial backing to Reform UK ahead of the next general election. In January 2025, he publicly fell out with Reform UK leader Nigel Farage, calling for Farage to be replaced as party leader. Musk subsequently shifted his backing towards Restore Britain, the political party launched by Rupert Lowe. In February 2026, Musk described Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez as a "tyrant" following Sánchez's proposal to prohibit minors under the age of 16 from accessing social media platforms.

## **Legal affairs**

In July 2018, Musk arranged for SpaceX and the Boring Company employees to build a mini-submarine to assist in the rescue of children trapped in a flooded cavern in Thailand. Despite him drawing attention to it on social media, the mini-submarine was deemed not practical for the rescue mission. A British diver interviewed about the mission, Vern Unsworth, reflected on Musk's actions collectively a "PR stunt". In response, Musk referred to Unsworth as a "pedo" in a tweet. In September, Unsworth filed a defamation suit seeking \$190 million in damages. Musk apologized and a jury later found Musk was not liable for the claim. In September 2018, Musk was sued by the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) for a tweet stating that funding had been secured for potentially taking Tesla private. The securities fraud lawsuit characterized the tweet as false, misleading, and damaging to investors, and sought to bar Musk from serving as CEO of publicly traded companies. Two days later, Musk settled with the SEC, without admitting or denying the SEC's allegations. As a result, Musk and Tesla were fined \$20 million each, and Musk was forced to step down for three years as Tesla chairman but was able to remain as CEO. Shareholders filed a lawsuit over the tweet, and in February 2023, a jury found Musk and Tesla not liable. Musk has stated in interviews that he does not regret posting the tweet that triggered the SEC investigation. In 2019, Musk stated in a tweet that Tesla would build half a million cars that year. The SEC reacted by asking a court to hold him in contempt for violating the terms of the 2018 settlement agreement. A joint agreement between Musk and the SEC eventually clarified

the previous agreement details, including a list of topics about which Musk needed preclearance. In 2020, a judge blocked a lawsuit that claimed a tweet by Musk regarding Tesla stock price ("too high imo") violated the agreement. Freedom of Information Act (FOIA)-released records showed that the SEC concluded Musk had subsequently violated the agreement twice by tweeting regarding "Tesla's solar roof production volumes and its stock price". In October 2023, the SEC sued Musk over his refusal to testify a third time in an investigation into whether he violated federal law by purchasing Twitter stock in 2022. In February 2024, Judge Laurel Beeler ruled that Musk must testify again. In January 2025, the SEC filed a lawsuit against Musk for securities violations related to his purchase of Twitter. In January 2024, Delaware judge Kathaleen McCormick ruled in a 2018 lawsuit that Musk's \$55 billion pay package from Tesla be rescinded. McCormick called the compensation granted by the company's board "an unfathomable sum" that was unfair to shareholders. The Delaware Supreme Court overturned McCormick's decision in December 2025, restoring Musk's compensation package and awarding \$1 in nominal damages. Musk exercised the stock options from his 2018 pay package on June 16, 2026. On March 20, 2026, a jury in San Francisco, California, found Musk liable for misleading investors during his acquisition of Twitter, though they absolved him of some fraud allegations, finding he did not "scheme" to defraud investors. Specifically, Musk was found to have misled shareholders in two tweets, but not in a podcast, as the views he expressed in that were deemed by the jury to be an opinion. Damages have yet to be calculated, but plaintiffs' lawyers estimated them to be \$2.5 billion. On May 18, 2026, a jury in Oakland, California, decided in favor of OpenAI and its executives, finding that Musk's February 2024 claims that the company violated its founding agreement by prioritizing profits over AI safety were barred by the statute of limitations.

## Personal life

Musk became a U.S. citizen in 2002. From the early 2000s until late 2020, Musk resided in California, where both Tesla and SpaceX were founded. He then relocated to Cameron County, Texas, saying that California had become "complacent" about its economic success. While hosting Saturday Night Live in 2021, Musk stated that he has Asperger syndrome. He was not diagnosed as a child. When asked about his experience growing up with Asperger's syndrome the following year, Musk stated that "the social cues were not intuitive ... I would just tend to take things very literally ... but then that turned out to be wrong—[people were not] simply saying exactly what they mean, there's all sorts of other things that are meant, and [it] took me a while to figure that out." Musk suffers from back pain and has undergone several spine-related surgeries, including a disc replacement. In 2000, he contracted a severe case of malaria while on vacation in South Africa. Musk has stated he uses doctor-prescribed ketamine for occasional depression and that he doses "a small amount once every other week or something like that"; since January 2024, some media outlets have reported that he takes ketamine, marijuana, LSD, ecstasy, mushrooms, cocaine and other drugs. Musk at first refused to comment on his alleged drug use, before responding that he had not tested positive for drugs, and that if drugs somehow improved his



productivity, "I would definitely take them!". The New York Times' investigations revealed Musk's overuse of ketamine and numerous other drugs, as well as strained family relationships and concerns from close associates who have become troubled by his public behavior as he became more involved in political activities and government work. According to The Washington Post, President Trump described Musk as "a big-time drug addict". Through his own label Emo G Records, Musk released a rap track, "RIP Harambe", on SoundCloud in March 2019. The following year, he released an EDM track, "Don't Doubt Ur Vibe", featuring his own lyrics and vocals. Musk plays video games, which he stated has a "'restoring effect' that helps his 'mental calibration'". Some games he plays include Quake, Diablo IV, Elden Ring, and Polytopia. Musk once claimed to be one of the world's top video game players but has since admitted to "account boosting", or cheating by hiring outside services to achieve top player rankings. Musk has justified the boosting by claiming that all top accounts do it so he has to as well to remain competitive. In 2024 and 2025, Musk criticized the video game Assassin's Creed Shadows and its creator Ubisoft for "woke" content. Musk posted to X that "DEI kills art" and specified the inclusion of the historical figure Yasuke in the Assassin's Creed game as offensive; he also called the game "terrible". Ubisoft responded by saying that Musk's comments were "just feeding hatred" and that they were focused on producing a game not pushing politics.

## **Relationships and children**

Musk has fathered at least 14 children, one of whom died as an infant. The Wall Street Journal reported in 2025 that sources close to Musk suggest that the "true number of Musk's children is much higher than publicly known". He had six children with his first wife, Canadian author Justine Wilson, whom he met while attending Queen's University in Ontario, Canada; they married in 2000. In 2002, their first child, Nevada Alexander Musk, died of sudden infant death syndrome at the age of 10 days. After his death, the couple used in vitro fertilization (IVF) to continue their family; they had twins in 2004, followed by triplets in 2006. The couple divorced in 2008 and have shared custody of their children. The elder twin he had with Wilson came out as a trans woman and, in 2022, officially changed her name to Vivian Jenna Wilson, adopting her mother's surname because she no longer wished to be associated with Musk. Musk began dating English actress Talulah Riley in 2008. They married two years later at Dornoch Cathedral in Scotland. In 2012, the couple divorced, then remarried the following year. After briefly filing for divorce in 2014, Musk finalized a second divorce from Riley in 2016. Musk then dated the American actress Amber Heard for several months in 2017; he had reportedly been "pursuing" her since 2012. In 2018, Musk and Canadian musician Grimes confirmed they were dating. Grimes and Musk have three children, born in 2020, 2021, and 2022. Musk and Grimes originally gave their eldest child the name "X Æ A-12", which would have violated California regulations as it contained characters that are not in the modern English alphabet; the names registered on the birth certificate are "X" as a first name, "Æ A-Xii" as a middle name, and "Musk" as a last name. They received criticism for choosing a name perceived to be impractical and difficult to pronounce; Musk has said the

intended pronunciation is "X Ash A Twelve". Their second child was born via surrogacy. Despite the pregnancy, Musk confirmed reports that the couple were "semi-separated" in September 2021; in an interview with Time in December 2021, he said he was single. In October 2023, Grimes sued Musk over parental rights and custody of X Æ A-Xii. Musk has taken X Æ A-Xii to multiple official events in Washington, D.C. during Trump's second term in office. Also in July 2022, The Wall Street Journal reported that Musk allegedly had an affair with Nicole Shanahan, the wife of Google co-founder Sergey Brin, in 2021, leading to their divorce the following year. Musk denied the report. Musk also had a relationship with Australian actress Natasha Bassett, who has been described as "an occasional girlfriend". In October 2024, The New York Times reported Musk bought a Texas compound for his children and their mothers, though Musk denied having done so. Musk also has four children with Shvonne Zilis, director of operations and special projects at Neuralink: twins born via IVF in 2021, a child born in 2024 via surrogacy and a child born in 2025. On February 14, 2025, Ashley St. Clair, an influencer and author, posted on X claiming to have given birth to Musk's son Romulus five months earlier, which media outlets reckoned as Musk's thirteenth child. On February 22, 2025, it was reported that St Clair had filed for sole custody of her five-month-old son and for Musk to be recognised as the child's father. On March 31, 2025, Musk wrote that, while he was unsure if he was the father of St. Clair's child, he had paid St. Clair \$2.5 million and would continue paying her \$500,000 per year. Later reporting from the Wall Street Journal indicated that \$1 million of these payments to St. Clair were structured as a loan.

## **Involvement with Jeffrey Epstein**

In 2014, Musk and Ghislaine Maxwell appeared together in a photograph taken at an Academy Awards after-party, which Musk later described as a "photobomb". The January 2026 Epstein files contain emails between Musk and Epstein from 2012 to 2013, after Epstein's first conviction. Emails released on January 30, 2026, indicated that Epstein invited Musk to visit his private island on multiple occasions. The correspondence showed that while Epstein repeatedly encouraged Musk to attend, Musk did not visit the island. In one instance, Musk discussed the possibility of attending a party with his then-wife Talulah Riley and asked which day would be the "wildest party"; according to the emails, the visit did not take place after Epstein later cancelled the plans. On Christmas day in 2012, Musk emailed Epstein asking "Do you have any parties planned? I've been working to the edge of sanity this year and so, once my kids head home after Christmas, I really want to hit the party scene in St Barts or elsewhere and let loose. The invitation is much appreciated, but a peaceful island experience is the opposite of what I'm looking for". Epstein replied that the "ratio on my island" might make Musk's wife uncomfortable to which Musk responded, "Ratio is not a problem for Talulah". On September 11, 2013, Epstein sent an email asking Musk if he had any plans for coming to New York for the opening of the United Nations General Assembly, saying that many "interesting people" would be coming to Epstein's house. Musk responded that "Flying to NY to see UN diplomats do nothing would be an unwise use of

time". Epstein responded by stating "Do you think i [sic] am retarded. Just kidding, there is no one over 25 and all very cute." Musk has denied any close relationship with Epstein and described him as a "creep" who attempted to ingratiate himself with influential people. When Musk was asked in 2019 if he introduced Epstein to Mark Zuckerberg, Musk responded: "I don't recall introducing Epstein to anyone, as I don't know the guy well enough to do so." The released emails nonetheless showed cordial exchanges on a range of topics, including Musk's inquiry about parties on the island. The correspondence also indicated that Musk suggested hosting Epstein at SpaceX, while Epstein separately discussed plans to tour SpaceX and bring "the girls", though there is no evidence that such a visit occurred. Musk has described the release of the files a "distraction", later accusing the second Trump administration of suppressing them to protect powerful individuals, including Trump himself.

## **Wealth**

### **Musk Foundation**

The Musk Foundation is a United States–based charitable foundation funded and directed primarily by Musk. The foundation is dedicated to promoting renewable energy, crewed space exploration, pediatrics, science and engineering education, and the "development of safe artificial intelligence for the benefit of humanity". At the end of 2024, the Musk Foundation had over \$14 billion in assets. Since 2020, donations have largely been sent to organizations affiliated with Musk and his businesses.

## **Public image**

Although his ventures have been highly influential within their separate industries starting in the 2000s, Musk only became a public figure in the early 2010s. He has been described as an eccentric who makes spontaneous and impactful decisions, while also often making controversial statements, contrary to other billionaires who prefer reclusiveness to protect their businesses. Musk's actions and his expressed views have made him a polarizing figure. Biographer Ashlee Vance described people's opinions of Musk as polarized due to his "part philosopher, part troll" persona on Twitter. He has drawn denouncement for using his platform to mock the self-selection of personal pronouns, while also receiving praise for bringing international attention to matters like British survivors of grooming gangs. Musk has been described as an American oligarch due to his extensive influence over public discourse, social media, industry, politics, and government policy. After Trump's re-election, Musk's influence and actions during the transition period and the second presidency of Donald Trump led some to call him "President Musk", the "actual president-elect", "shadow president" or "co-president".

## **Accolades**

Awards for his contributions to the development of the Falcon rockets include the American Institute of Aeronautics and Astronautics George Low Transportation Award in 2008, the Fédération Aéronautique Internationale Gold Space Medal in 2010, and the Royal Aeronautical Society Gold Medal in 2012. In 2015, he received an honorary doctorate in engineering and technology from Yale University and an Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers Honorary Membership. Musk was elected a Fellow of the Royal Society (FRS) in 2018. In 2022, Musk was elected to the National Academy of Engineering. Time has listed Musk as one of the most influential people in the world in 2010, 2013, 2018, and 2021. Musk was selected as Time's "Person of the Year" for 2021. Then Time editor-in-chief Edward Felsenthal wrote that, "Person of the Year is a marker of influence, and few individuals have had more influence than Musk on life on Earth, and potentially life off Earth too."

## Further reading

Conger, Kate; Mac, Ryan (2024). *Character Limit: How Elon Musk Destroyed Twitter* (1st hardcover ed.). New York: Penguin Press. ISBN 978-0593656136. OCLC 1432234243. Farrow, Ronan (August 28, 2023) [August 21, 2023 (online)]. "Elon Musk's Shadow Rule". *A Reporter at Large* (story series). The New Yorker. Retrieved August 25, 2023. Tarnoff, Ben (January 18, 2024). ""Ultra Hardcore" (review of Walter Isaacson, *Elon Musk*, Simon and Schuster, 2023, 670 pp.)". The New York Review of Books. There is an anti-modern impulse to Musk, a craving for lordship that can't be entirely satisfied within the confines of a capitalist economy. A king doesn't have advertisers or shareholders or customers, and Musk, if he continues on his current trajectory, may very well be abandoned by all three. Aristotle says a good ending should be surprising but inevitable. It's possible to imagine multiple finales for Musk that meet these criteria, but the story always begins the same way. Once upon a time in Pretoria, there was a boy who wanted to be a man.

## External links

Appearances on C-SPAN Elon Musk on LittleSis, a website that publishes data on who-knows-who between government, donors and business Elon Musk on X Elon Musk at IMDb

# Chapter 4

## Recent Developments and Current Work

---

### Elon Musk trolls OpenAI CEO Sam Altman over Apple trade secrets suit - Yahoo Finance

Yahoo Finance | 2026-07-13

Elon Musk has inserted himself into the legal battle between Apple ( AAPL ) and OpenAI ( OPAI.PVT ). The SpaceX ( SPCX ) and Tesla ( TSLA ) CEO took to X over the weekend, taking several shots at OpenAI CEO Sam Altman and accusing him of "scamming." Musk, who co-founded OpenAI alongside Altman and others, lost a lawsuit against the AI startup's chief executive and president Greg Brockman. In his suit, Musk accused the pair and OpenAI backer Microsoft ( MSFT ) of duping him into donating money to the company with the understanding that it would remain a nonprofit. In one post on X, Musk said Altman "takes scamming to a whole new level." Altman replied, criticizing Musk for "selling public market investors on short-term space datacenters," referring to SpaceX's plans to launch space-based data centers as an alternative to ground-based solutions. Musk shot back, saying the company will begin flying the data centers next year, while claiming, "After stealing an open source AI charity, you then stole all of Apple's phone technology!" Apple revealed its lawsuit against OpenAI in a court filing on Friday, claiming "OpenAI and its cohorts have been engaging in a coordinated pattern of misconduct at an institutional level." In a statement, an OpenAI spokesperson told Yahoo Finance, "We have no interest in other companies' trade secrets. We remain focused on building innovative technology that empowers people everywhere." Apple alleges in its suit that Tang Tan, OpenAI's hardware chief and former Apple vice president of product design, and Chang Liu, a former Apple electrical engineer who now works at OpenAI, colluded to steal information from the iPhone maker that would help OpenAI build its own AI devices. According to the suit, Tan emailed himself information about Apple's suppliers before leaving the company and joining OpenAI. He also allegedly asked prospective OpenAI candidates who were still employed by Apple to bring "actual parts" to interviews for "show and tell" sessions. Liu, Apple claims, used a former Apple colleague's Apple-issued laptop to access the company's network and downloaded hardware-related files about unreleased products and other proprietary data. The lawsuit states that other former Apple employees who moved on to OpenAI similarly emailed themselves confidential Apple information to their private email accounts, while others used their knowledge of Apple's trade secrets to help OpenAI create its AI hardware devices. Apple said OpenAI currently employs more than 400 former Apple workers. Email Daniel Howley at [dhowley@yahoofinance.com](mailto:dhowley@yahoofinance.com). Follow him on X at [@DanielHowley](https://twitter.com/DanielHowley) . Click here for the latest technology news that will impact the stock market .

# Elon Musk's SpaceX IPO made history. One month on has it lost momentum? - BBC

BBC | 2026-07-13

SpaceX investors have swung from celebration to apparent concern in its first month as a publicly traded company. When shares in the firm, co-founded and led by Elon Musk, first became available for individuals to buy on the public stock market on 12 June, there was an investor frenzy. Although the company had decided to price its shares at \$135 each, the price immediately shot up to \$150 that first day, climbing to \$176, before closing at \$160.95. It solidified SpaceX as the largest initial public offering (IPO) of all time. The following week, its shares went up even further, hitting an intraday high of \$225, meaning it had surpassed Amazon and Microsoft in total market value. "With Elon Musk, any company he touches gets people excited," Keith Snyder, analyst at investment research firm CFRA, said. "But this was also the first time people felt like they were able to invest in something that was being marketed as an AI play." Willy Lee, an investor at Neosteller, which facilitates individual investors putting money into private companies, agreed that the excitement around the IPO was very much around artificial intelligence (AI). SpaceX earlier this year acquired Musk's AI start-up xAI, recently renamed SpaceXAI and best known for the controversial chatbot Grok, and also started leasing data centre capacity to other tech companies. But its main business is the manufacture and launch of rockets and telecommunications satellites called Starlink. When Starlink said it was cutting prices in the Memphis, Tennessee area amid local concerns over a massive data centre project, SpaceX shares fell on the day by 8%. As the reality of how SpaceX currently makes money has seemed to come into clearer focus, the company's shares have started to sink. Even amid a tumultuous couple of weeks for tech stocks, SpaceX has taken a particular hit. When it was added to the Nasdaq100 index on 7 July, for instance, although the index closed down 1.7%, SpaceX fell 4.4%. An earlier addition to the FTSE Russell index had given the shares a slight boost. At the end of its first trading month, shares of SpaceX were selling at around \$145 each, roughly 18% less than the high on its first day of trading, and 35% less than its peak so far. Such a drop in price means that retail investors who purchased SpaceX stock during its first five days of trading are looking at a potential loss on their investment. "If you bought around the first tick you're definitely underwater," Snyder said. "It started to look a lot like a meme stock," Snyder added, pointing to the examples of GameStop and, more recently, Wendy's, where retail investors drive up a stock price through little more than excited online conversation. He expects SpaceX to dip even further, to around \$115 a share, based on the company's business performance. That would value the company at around \$1.5 trillion. Samuel Kerr, who heads analysis of equity capital markets for Mergermarket, noted that the swings in the share price so far will have had a different impact on different investors. "If you're an IPO investor, you're ok," Kerr said, referring to groups of investors who were either able to buy SpaceX at the company's proposed listing price of \$135, or who were insiders with pre-IPO equity in the company. "If you bought in the first few days, you're not very

happy right now," Kerr added. Nevertheless, Musk has expressed little but enthusiasm for the business prospects of SpaceX. After the company's public listing made him the world's first trillionaire, Musk said that SpaceX would pull in \$1tn in yearly revenue by 2030. Musk has also shown that he is ready and willing to use SpaceX shares, and their volatility, as a currency. When the share price spiked on 16 June, SpaceX announced it was acquiring Cursor, a start-up that created an AI bot for writing computer code, in an all-stock deal valued at \$60bn. By doing so at that time, Musk essentially bought Cursor for free, given how much value SpaceX stock had gained at that exact time. "It showed a level of market sophistication that almost no other issuer has," Kerr said of the Cursor acquisition. Morgan Stanley, which was a lead banker on the SpaceX IPO, seems to think the dip will be an interlude. It last week initiated coverage by its financial analysts and put a target share price on the company of \$300, a 33% jump from its highest trading price to date. SpaceX currently operates at a loss and last year it made \$18bn in revenue, according to financial disclosures required for it to go public. At the moment, anticipation is building around the company's first public earnings report. SpaceX has not yet announced a date for this, but financial analysts are expecting it to happen in early August. The company's earnings will likely coincide with the end of what's known as a "lock-up" period, when SpaceX employees who have been prohibited from selling shares in the firm that they received as part of their compensation will be able to shift them on to the open market. More shares for sale, plus a potentially more detailed explanation of SpaceX's business and future growth could create further dramatic swings in price. "If SpaceX can do all the things it says it will do, yes, investors are sitting on the most valuable company ever," Kerr said.

## **Elon Musk's Bastrop area empire triples land holdings - The Real Deal**

The Real Deal | 2026-07-14

Elon Musk's dizzying array of tech companies have tripled their real estate in Bastrop County east of Austin since May. FM 969, a rural roadway that connects Bastrop to Austin, has quickly become the hub of Musk's activities in the Austin area, according to a review of their holdings by the Austin Business Journal. Over the past few months, the data reviewed by the outlet showed that entities tied to Musk have around 2,000 acres worth of space in Bastrop, compared to the 700 acres he was tied to earlier in the year. In June, Musk publicly insinuated that he had about 1,000 acres either owned or under contract. Musk affiliates have snagged upwards of 1,360 acres in the past three or so months, according to the outlet. What Musk plans to do with the land is currently opaque. His new Gigasat solar factory, which is set to span 11 million square feet, is on land previously owned by SpaceX. SpaceX has not submitted any permits for the new parcels, according to the outlet. Since Musk personally moved to Austin in 2020, the companies tied to his burgeoning empire have trickled in behind him. The first was Tesla, which constructed the \$10 billion Gigafactory at 13101 Tesla Road in 2021, just a stone's throw from Austin-Bergstrom

International Airport. X, formerly known as Twitter, moved to Austin and SpaceX moved to Starbase, Texas. xAI, the artificial intelligence firm tied to X, subleased around 112,000 square feet of office space at the Seaholm Power Plant along the Colorado River in Downtown Austin. The SpaceX Gigasat solar production facility is aimed at shooting data centers into space, with the goal of operating 6,500 satellites by the end of 2027. The Terafab, a \$20-billion-plus semiconductor fabrication plant, is expected to begin production in Grimes County in 2027. What Musk will do, exactly, with the new land in Bastrop is currently unknown.

## **Pollution from Musk's unpermitted xAI power project hits hardest in Black communities - Reuters**

Reuters | 2026-07-14

Pollution from Musk's unpermitted xAI power project hits hardest in Black communities Reuters

## **Proposed Seahawks owner Vinod Khosla has battled on social media with Elon Musk - NBC Sports**

NBC Sports | 2026-07-14

As a wise man once told me, the only thing better than being rich and famous is being rich. And while proposed Seahawks owner Vinod Khosla has achieved a certain amount of notoriety through his entrepreneurial efforts, the purchase of one of the 32 most desirable sports assets in the country invites a much higher level of attention and scrutiny. Maybe that's one of the reasons Khosla's wife, Neeru, will serve as the controlling owner of the team. It will keep Vinod one step removed from the intense glare of NFL ownership. That said, Vinod Khosla has welcomed the periodic spotlight. For example, he has publicly tussled with fellow multibillionaire Elon Musk on the social-media platform Musk owns. Two years ago, after incumbent Joe Biden exited the race for the presidency, Musk wanted Khosla to climb aboard the Trump train. Said Khosla: "Hard for me to support someone with no values, lies, cheats, rapes, demeans women, hates immigrants like me . He may cut taxes or reduce some regulation but that is no reason to accept depravity in his personal values." More recently, Khosla said (via Forbes ) that Musk "doesn't want MAGA, he wants WAGA or 'white America great again' as a 'racism is great and desirable" paradigm." Khosla also urged non-white employees of Musk's companies to quit their jobs and work for Khosla instead. Musk called Khosla a "pompous asshole" and said he had gone "full r-tard." Similar squabbles in the future will draw far more attention, as those who cover the NFL pay closer attention to any and all of Khosla's public comments.

## **Newsom botches claim California regs created Tesla, not Musk - Fox News**



Elizabeth MacDonald discusses Gavin Newsom's claim that California regulations fostered Tesla's success, not Elon Musk's genius. Tiffany Smiley, Endeavor PAC founder, criticizes California Governor Gavin Newsom's "wild new hot take" that state regulations created Tesla, not Elon Musk. Smiley argues Newsom is desperate for positive news amid California's decline due to his policies and taxation, which caused Elon Musk to move Tesla to Texas. She suggests Newsom's statements are part of his presidential aspirations.

## **Elon Musk is building a form of capitalism that Adam Smith would hate - The Economist**

The Economist | 2026-07-12

Elon Musk is building a form of capitalism that Adam Smith would hate The Economist

## **Musk's Net Worth Drops Below \$900 Billion With SpaceX Nearing IPO Value - Forbes**

Forbes | 2026-07-13

Elon Musk's net worth dipped below \$900 billion on Monday as shares in his SpaceX slid toward their initial public offering price, even as analysts remain overwhelmingly bullish on the rocket maker. Shares of SpaceX dropped 3.8% to just under \$140 as of Monday afternoon, approaching the stock's \$135 IPO price, as Tesla similarly declined 3%. Another pullback in SpaceX shares cut \$37.9 billion from Musk's net worth, valued at \$879.3 billion, as he remains the world's richest person—directly ahead of Google cofounders Larry Page (\$290.1 billion) and Sergey Brin (\$267.6 billion). Musk holds 4.8 billion SpaceX shares and another 350 million stock options, in addition to roughly 700 million Tesla shares. \$1.45 trillion. That's the peak of Musk's net worth, achieved on June 16 as SpaceX shares hit an all-time high, above \$225. Since then, the stock has plunged more than 38%. Even as SpaceX shares stumble, Wall Street is largely bullish on the stock: Raymond James set an \$800 price target, implying a market valuation well above \$10 trillion. Brokers on average expect SpaceX shares to be worth \$236, according to FactSet data, with targets of \$401 from Arete Research, \$300 from Morgan Stanley and \$205 from Goldman Sachs. Raymond James analyst Brian Gesuale argued his firm's position on SpaceX came as Musk's rocket maker was "building the foundational platform for the next generation of industrial capacity." SpaceX's stock has been volatile since a record-setting debut last month. Shares of SpaceX peaked at an all-time high just a day after its IPO, after which the stock has declined in 11 of 17 total trading sessions. Longtime Tesla bull Dan Ives wrote in a note for Wedbush Securities that SpaceX was "one of the most differentiated assets within the tech market." Ives also argued Musk's rocket maker was "well-positioned to become a major hyperscaler" across connectivity,

rocket launches and AI infrastructure.

## **James Murdoch may have reaped as much as \$7.5 billion from his pre-IPO investment in Elon Musk's SpaceX - Fortune**

Fortune | 2026-07-12

James Murdoch appears poised to reap a fortune from his investments in SpaceX that could far exceed what he gained from his father's media empire. James, the estranged 53-year-old son of Rupert Murdoch, invested an estimated \$120 million in Elon Musk's rocket company before it went public this year in the biggest IPO in history. James' holding could now be worth as much as \$7.5 billion, according to calculations by Pitchbook's Franco Granda, senior research analyst for private company coverage. The valuation has not previously been publicly disclosed. His success could come as a rebuke to his father, who during an internal family fight once instructed a lawyer to suggest that his youngest son could never have succeeded without him. Fortune reached out to Blair Effron, a partner at Centerview Partners, which has advised the Murdoch family on investment decisions. He said, "As a friend of James, I'll pass on speaking." A representative for James Murdoch had no comment at press time. The financials are based on details of James' holdings found in public records. A 2023 court case brought by a Tesla shareholder challenging Musk's controversial \$56 billion compensation package revealed that James had bought three separate tranches of stock in SpaceX. Two of those tranches, worth \$50 million each, were acquired in 2019 and 2020 via a private investment firm, thought to be Murdoch's Lupa Systems, where he is the primary beneficiary, along with staff and partners. He separately bought another \$20 million as a personal investment in 2019. Those stakes together are now estimated to be worth between \$6.573 billion and \$7.44 billion, according to the Pitchbook estimate. While the SpaceX S-1 document attached to its public offering, doesn't mention James Murdoch, it details stock awards to its chief financial officer, Bret Johnsen, that have an expiration date of 2030 and value the stock at \$4.40—numbers that give clues as to the value of owned by shareholders before the IPO. There are, however, a series of caveats. James Murdoch could have sold those SpaceX shares along the way, and there have been several dilutions. The company approved a five-to-one stock split in May, for instance. The precise dates of the stock acquisitions are not publicly known, but media industry executives have been exchanging rumors about the junior Murdoch's astonishing potential windfall. The former chief executive of 21st Century Fox was already a multi-billionaire. He stepped down from Fox after the majority of its assets were sold in a \$71.3 billion deal with Disney in 2019, garnering him \$2.2 billion in proceeds. James' split with his father became final when the elder Murdoch rejected him in favor of his brother Lachlan to succeed Rupert atop News Corp. Last year, a Nevada probate court examined a move by Rupert and his eldest son Lachlan Murdoch to change a longstanding Murdoch Family Trust, which had been designed to protect the financial interests of all six Murdoch children. A probate commissioner ruled against the change that would have stripped voting rights from James and his

sisters Liz and Prue. After an appeal, the parties came to an agreement that resulted in each of the three siblings receiving a \$1.1 billion payout. The agreement stipulated that Murdoch children shed their stock in News Corp and Fox. The private fight spilled out into public view after the New York Times and The Atlantic revealed the full extent of the animosity between James Murdoch and his father. The two no longer speak. The Atlantic published an interview with James, who believed his father was feeding questions to a lawyer. One of the questions posed was, "Have you ever done anything successful on your own?" James first met Musk in the late nineties, according to the court filings in the shareholder fight. At that time, Musk was building Zip2, an online guide to cities and businesses for newspapers while James was running digital operations at what was then known simply as News Corp, before Fox split off. The two men reconnected after James ordered an electric Tesla Roadster in the middle of the 2000s. They continued to meet up and went on family vacations to Israel, Mexico, and the Bahamas. After one of the trips, Musk talked to his brother Kimbal and later added James Murdoch to the Tesla board, according to an account in the court documents from the now-resolved compensation battle. James Murdoch has profited handsomely from his Tesla shares, which he holds within JRM Rev Trust and another financial entity called Seven Hills Trust. Tesla share sales have netted the JRM Rev Trust \$107 million since Spring last year, according to SEC documents. Tesla also owns 19 million shares in SpaceX, potentially benefiting James Murdoch. There are Street rumors that Tesla may be folded into SpaceX too. James is currently listed as an independent director who joined Tesla in July 2017. The revelations give weight to the idea that James Murdoch has been a canny investor since his exit from Fox. Musk was spotted sitting with Rupert and daughter Liz Murdoch at the Super Bowl in 2023 and shared that he had discussed his Dogecoin initiatives. That was the year Rupert and Lachlan tried to figure out a way to change the irrevocable family trust to solidify Lachlan's control over the companies, ostensibly to avoid disputes boiling over after Rupert passes away—a move that ultimately triggered the probate fight. James has been setting his own course since the Disney sale, establishing his own investment firm Lupa Systems in New York in 2019. That year, SpaceX began launching broadband satellites that became part of Starlink, a business that James Murdoch knows well, having run two satellite pay-TV ventures, Sky in the U.K. and Star in Asia. After exiting Fox, James began investing in a host of businesses both in the media and beyond. Most recently, he made a \$300 million deal to acquire a large portion of Vox Media, owner of New York magazine, a brace of niche websites, and a collection of podcasts from the likes of tech journalist Kara Swisher and Professor Scott Galloway. He has made a host of other investments that span the arts, including comic book publisher and studio AWA ; Tribeca Enterprises , the Robert De Niro and Jane Rosenthal-helmed Tribeca Film Festival owner; and MCH Group, the holding company of global art show Art Basel. James is also invested in a streaming media service joint venture in India through Bodhi Tree Systems, which received funds from Comcast and the Qatar Investment Authority. "To me this is no surprise, James has been a savvy global technology investor for decades," said Jon Miller, the chief executive of TPG-backed Integrated Media. Miller is a former CEO of AOL and was the chief digital officer at News Corp overseeing Hulu. Veteran media analyst Brian Wieser of media and marketing focused advisory

firm Madison and Wall believes it's very hard to say with certainty what the actual potential windfall might be but acknowledges it's likely significant if James Murdoch bought shares at \$4.40 in 2020 those shares, and the ones acquired in 2019 have grown 33x. He said: "Given that James Murdoch has been in the SpaceX orbit for a while, since Tesla, it's unsurprising that he's benefited financially. And if so, it's very plausible that someone like James Murdoch could end up making a lot more from the holdings of SpaceX than they ever would from holding traditional media companies. Though that presumes they can get liquid, holding the shares doesn't mean anything if you can't sell them."— With reporting by Amanda Gerut. Claire Atkinson is the author of an upcoming new biography of Rupert Murdoch for Grand Central Publishing, scheduled to be published in 2027.

## **Elon Musk thinks SpaceX's value could outgrow Earth itself - MSN**

MSN | 2026-07-14

Elon Musk thinks SpaceX's value could outgrow Earth itself MSN

# References

---

- 1 [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Elon\\_Musk](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Elon_Musk)
- 2 <https://finance.yahoo.com/technology/article/elon-musk-trolls-openai-ceo-sam-altman-over-apple-trade-secrets-suit-181116261.html>
- 3 <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c3wyj6e4210o>
- 4 <https://therealdeal.com/texas/2026/07/14/elon-musk-triples-down-on-land-in-bastrop/>
- 5 <https://www.reuters.com/world/americas/pollution-musks-unpermitted-xai-power-project-hits-hardest-black-communities-2026-07-14/>
- 6 <https://www.nbcsports.com/nfl/profootballtalk/rumor-mill/news/proposed-seahawks-owner-vinod-khosla-has-battled-on-social-media-with-elon-musk>
- 7 <https://www.foxnews.com/video/6401123868112>
- 8 <https://www.economist.com/by-invitation/2026/07/12/elon-musk-is-building-a-form-of-capitalism-that-adam-smith-would-hate>
- 9 <https://www.forbes.com/sites/tylerroush/2026/07/13/elon-musks-fortune-falls-below-900-billion-as-spacex-slide-worsens/>
- 10 <https://fortune.com/2026/07/12/james-murdoch-7-5-billion-ipo-elon-musk-spacex/>
- 11 <https://www.msn.com/en-us/money/markets/elon-musk-thinks-spacex-s-value-could-outgrow-earth-itself/ar-AA27TFsO?ocid>